

Chapter 107-1

When Xu Qingzhu said the two characters "jiejie," her enunciation was always a bit strange.

There was an indescribable tenderness and sweetness to it.

More heart-stirring than any other term of address.

Just like this morning when she called out "jiejie" at home—it made Liang Shi's heart itch.

Even after leaving that situation, just thinking about it would make one subconsciously pinch their earlobe.

Her ears felt hot.

But at this moment, Liang Shi asked: "Why someone from when you were little?"

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly, turning the steering wheel to make a turn. Her cool voice carried nostalgia and longing, full of tenderness: "Because we haven't seen each other for a very long time."

"Then why not go see her?" Liang Shi said. "You like her so much."

When she said the second half, Liang Shi's voice was very soft.

She lowered her eyes, her fingers casually swiping across her phone screen—though the screen was actually black.

Swiping back and forth, there was nothing to look at.

But it was better than looking sideways at Xu Qingzhu.

When mentioning the jiejie she hadn't seen for a long time, Xu Qingzhu's tone was light and slow, and her smile was gentle.

It was a rare expression to see.

When Liang Shi said that half-sentence, her heart still held a faint expectation.

Holding her breath.

But Xu Qingzhu answered lightly: "She doesn't remember me anymore."

Splat.

The heart that had been waiting for Xu Qingzhu's denial fell.

Liang Shi had an indescribable feeling, like sinking into the deep sea—very suffocating.

She pressed the car window button. The chaotic wind blew her hair back and brought a chill to her face, giving her some clarity.

Liang Shi slowly adjusted her breathing, trying to sound as normal as possible, and said gently: "That's really a pity."

The falling tone of "pity" didn't actually sound all that regretful.

The car stopped at a red light. Xu Qingzhu glanced at Liang Shi from the corner of her eye, watching her fingers casually swipe across the dark screen, watching her lower her eyes as if lost in thought.

Xu Qingzhu curled her fingers and tapped on the steering wheel, tapping out a soothing rhythm.

A piano piece was playing on the car stereo.

"Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu's tone lifted slightly as she called out to her in a low voice.

Liang Shi responded: "Mm."

"Unhappy?" Xu Qingzhu asked lightly.

Liang Shi instinctively denied it: "Not at all. I'm quite happy."

Xu Qingzhu: "Oh?"

The car started moving again, accelerating to merge into the traffic flow.

After a moment, Liang Shi's voice sounded in the car, carrying an almost imperceptible helplessness as she corrected her earlier answer: "I am a little bit unhappy."

—Only a little bit.

Xu Qingzhu smiled with curved lips. The wind blew in from Liang Shi's side of the car window, passing by Liang Shi before reaching her.

It somehow felt gentler.

The piano piece was gentle and lingering, intertwined with the sound of the wind. Xu Qingzhu's cool voice sounded in the car: "What is there to be unhappy about?"

Liang Shi glanced sideways at her and saw that she was smiling.

The corners of her eyes lifted—a cunning and satisfied smile.

Liang Shi's mood unconsciously relaxed. She retorted: "You wouldn't understand."

Xu Qingzhu nodded, playing along: "Yes, yes, yes. I don't understand."

Liang Shi felt her attitude was perfunctory and scoffed lightly: "I already said it's only a little bit."

"Oh." Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue. "So I only have a little bit of importance. Got it."

Liang Shi: "....."

"That's not what I meant." Liang Shi wanted to explain, but Xu Qingzhu cut her off: "Then what did you mean?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She was suddenly at a loss for words.

Liang Shi, who had never been good with words in this regard, didn't know what adjectives to use to describe her feelings when her emotions were too complex.

Let alone at this moment.

So after a few seconds of silence, she turned her head to look out the window and slowed her voice: "Whatever you think it is, that's what it is."

Liang Shi said: "I'm not good with words. I can't out-talk you."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"Are you angry?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "No."

After saying that, fearing Xu Qingzhu wouldn't believe her, she added: "Really."

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but smile. The amusement swirled in her eyes, but she didn't show it on her face, which still maintained its cool expression.

But as soon as she spoke, she gave herself away: "If you're angry, there's nothing I can do about it."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Teacher Xu." Liang Shi turned her head again to look at Xu Qingzhu, who was driving with a serious expression.

Cold air swept through the car. Xu Qingzhu's sleeves were rolled up a bit, and the exposed section of her arm had turned slightly red from the cold wind. On her wrist was a diamond-studded watch with a black band, which made her skin look even whiter.

Xu Qingzhu was driving and found her hair flying around annoying, as it affected her vision. So she had tied her long hair into a loose ponytail, leaving some stray hairs on both sides of her face that kept being blown about.

The curve of her profile was also impossibly beautiful.

Facing her, Liang Shi's heart always softened. She had originally wanted to make a jab at her, but by the time the words reached her lips, they had turned into a helpless tone: "Stop teasing me."

Xu Qingzhu feigned surprise: "Huh? Am I?"

"You are." Liang Shi gritted her teeth as she called her name, helplessness mixed with a hint of tenderness: "Xu Qingzhu, I'm already angry."

It should have been an icy cold statement, but spoken in her gentle voice, it carried an alluring ambiguity.

Xu Qingzhu's heart stirred at those words, but she didn't show it on her face.

She let the silence spread through the car.

Chapter 107-2

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally spoke languidly. Her cool voice was lazy, the ending tone lifting with a hint of teasing: "Teacher Liang."

Liang Shi glanced at her.

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "Why are you getting worked up over someone who's lost their memory?"

Liang Shi: "....."

The other person had forgotten you, yet you still remember her!

And she's even your favorite person!

This didn't make sense.

But Liang Shi didn't say anything, quietly waiting for Xu Qingzhu to continue.

Sure enough, after a moment, Xu Qingzhu's voice became even more languid. When she spoke, her words ran together, carrying a bit of alluring tenderness: "What I've always liked is —"

She drew out her tone, those beautiful eyes landing on Liang Shi for just a moment before moving away.

This pause made her words even more convincing, almost enunciated word by word.

She said: "Cherishing the person in front of me."

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Who the person in front of her was—that went without saying.

Liang Shi's mood improved greatly because of those five characters. After closing the car window, she even changed the car music to a slow rock song.

They quickly arrived at Yujiang Bridge. Along the way, they passed by her neighborhood. Liang Shi suddenly remarked: "After we moved here, it seems like we've never actually walked across that bridge."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "We've both been too busy."

The direction of Xu Qingzhu's company didn't require crossing the bridge, and although Liang Shi often drove out, she had never been on that bridge either.

They had only looked down at the full view of the bridge from home. Sometimes when spacing out, they would stand there watching the scenery on the bridge for a long time—not just watching the flow of the river, but also the people and cars coming and going on the bridge. They would watch for more than half an hour at a time.

Even so, they had never actually walked across this bridge.

Driving onto the bridge was completely different from the angle of looking down from their building. The scenery they saw was also completely different.

The speed of the river's flow seemed to slow down. The cars nearby were moving very fast, but the pedestrian paths on both sides of the bridge seemed unusually slow.

Liang Shi sat in the passenger seat, continuously looking at both sides. When the car had driven halfway across, Liang Shi said: "I see her."

You couldn't stop on the side of the bridge for long—three minutes of temporary parking at most.

After Xu Qingzhu pulled over to the side, she let Liang Shi get out, then drove the car off the bridge.

Liang Wanwan was wearing a thin white shirt, high-waisted jeans, white sneakers, with her hair in a bun, exposing her smooth forehead. It was a very youthful and innocent college student outfit. The collar of her white shirt even had a black bow tie.

The shirt was billowing in the wind. Just looking at her made you feel cold.

Liang Shi jogged over and called out: "Wanwan."

Liang Wanwan, who had been looking down at the ground, finally raised her head. When she saw it was Liang Shi, tears immediately gathered in her already red eyes and fell without hesitation.

She raised the back of her hand to wipe them away, then stood up from the bench.

Liang Shi took out tissues from her pocket, pulled one out, folded it, and handed it to her.

Liang Wanwan wiped her tears before calling out in a choked voice: "Jie."

Her cheeks were red from the cold. Her nose was even redder than her cheeks. All the skin that was exposed had turned red, and there was a fine layer of goosebumps on her neck from the cold. She couldn't help but shiver while talking to Liang Shi.

She looked cold just watching her.

Haizhou City's weather was already approaching winter. Although it was a coastal city, it was classified as northern in terms of regional planning.

In these last days of autumn, the nighttime temperature could drop below zero at any time.

But Liang Wanwan was wearing a summer white shirt.

Liang Shi also understood how these young girls dressed—wearing little underneath and a thick coat on the outside. Once they went indoors and took off the heavy coat, they'd be a slender fairy again.

But that was only for winter.

In late autumn, Haizhou City's indoor temperature was sometimes even worse than outdoors.

Liang Shi couldn't understand these young girls, but at the end of the day, it was all about looking beautiful. Looking at her two slender legs in light-colored jeans, Liang Shi guessed she wasn't wearing long underwear underneath—just thin jeans.

No wonder she was cold.

Liang Shi didn't ask about those matters first. She took off her own coat and draped it over Liang Wanwan's shoulders. "How long have you been here?"

"I don't know," Liang Wanwan said with a snuffle. Her voice was nasally—she sounded like she was about to catch a cold.

Liang Shi asked her: "Are you still going back to school tonight?"

"I don't want to go back." Liang Wanwan looked aggrieved. With reddened eyes again, she said to Liang Shi: "Jie, Chen Mian's sketchbook..."

But Liang Shi interrupted her: "Then come stay at my place tonight?"

She watched Liang Wanwan put on her coat.

Liang Wanwan was much shorter than her—just over 160 centimeters¹. Wearing her coat, the hem fell below her knees, covering half of her calves. The sleeves were also too long.

And after putting it on, she didn't button it up. The cold wind was still rushing in.

Liang Shi couldn't help but frown watching this. She buttoned up the coat—buttons that looked merely decorative—for Liang Wanwan, and also pulled the collar tight, not giving the cold wind any room to breathe.

But Liang Wanwan couldn't hold back a sneeze, getting it all over Liang Shi's hand.

"I'm sorry." Liang Wanwan apologized timidly.

Liang Shi looked down at the back of her hand, helpless: "It's fine."

She wiped it off with a tissue. Liang Wanwan clutched her own collar tightly and said in a low voice: "Is it convenient for you?"

She was asking about the question Liang Shi had asked earlier.

Hearing her words, and thinking back to what she had just said, Liang Shi finally realized something was off.

How had their conversation gotten a bit... strange?

It was like she was bringing her little lover home.

Liang Shi chased those wild thoughts out of her mind and said to her in a low voice: "Your Qingzhu-jie is waiting for us at the bottom of the bridge. Let's go—to my place."

Wearing Liang Shi's coat, Liang Wanwan followed closely behind her, step by step.

Footnotes:

¹ 160 centimeters: Approximately 5 feet 3 inches.

Chapter 107-3

Xu Qingzhu had been waiting in the car. After Liang Shi got out, Xu Qingzhu turned on the heater to warm up the car.

She guessed that Liang Wanwan had also been on the bridge for a long time and was probably freezing badly.

Today's weather was approaching zero degrees. The wind on the bridge was strong, so it was probably even lower than zero. When Xu Qingzhu drove the car over, she had noticed ice crystals on the bridge, and the wheels had slipped a little. While it was drizzling elsewhere, here it had already turned into sleet because of the low temperature.

The car was now warm enough. She was wearing a coat and actually felt a bit hot—especially since she had been leaning against the car seat, and her back had gotten a bit damp.

She took off her wool coat and tossed it in the back seat, idly switching the car music while waiting for Liang Shi and Liang Wanwan.

When Liang Shi and Liang Wanwan were walking down from the bridge, Xu Qingzhu noticed them.

Liang Shi was tall. Though thin, she was tall after all—no matter how thin she was, she was still much better off than Liang Wanwan. Moreover, Liang Shi's thinness wasn't a sickly kind of thin, but a lean and strong kind of thin. She had given her coat to Liang Wanwan to wear and was only wearing a light gray crew-neck sweatshirt, the same dark jeans as Xu Qingzhu—which fit a bit tight on her—and black high-top boots that had gotten muddy from walking on the rain-soaked roads.

She walked in front, which happened to block the wind for Liang Wanwan.

Liang Wanwan probably hadn't noticed that Liang Shi had been maintaining an appropriate distance from her the whole time, blocking all the cold wind for her.

And Liang Shi herself was cold too, but she didn't show it.

She was toughing it out.

Xu Qingzhu's gaze never left them.

Liang Wanwan was the type who did everything slowly, which was why she could sit in front of an easel for an entire day. Even her walking was like this, so Liang Shi slowed her pace to accommodate her.

This scene was actually quite nice to look at, especially as they walked unhurriedly through this city. Rain was floating down from the sky—not heavy, just a few strands of drizzle that wouldn't even dampen clothes when it landed on you.

But no matter how Xu Qingzhu looked at it, she felt... uncomfortable.

Liang Wanwan wasn't Liang Shi's biological sister.

Yet she still intimately called her "jie."

Liang Shi would give her own coat to her, would stand in front of her to shield her from wind and rain.

Liang Shi was gentle to everyone.

Not just to her.

At this moment, Xu Qingzhu seemed to understand what kind of feeling Liang Shi meant when she said she was "a little bit unhappy."

Yes, a little bit unhappy.

But she couldn't quite put it into words.

Until Liang Shi opened the car door for Liang Wanwan. After getting in the car, Liang Wanwan greeted her: "Qingzhu-jie."

Xu Qingzhu nodded at her and asked in what could be considered a gentle tone: "Cold?"

After Liang Shi got in the car and felt the warmth, she said while fastening her seatbelt: "It's so cold outside."

Liang Wanwan nodded: "It is cold."

Their words overlapped, and even their tones were somewhat similar.

Then Liang Wanwan asked: "Jie, where do you live now?"

Liang Shi answered: "Near this bridge."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

At this moment, she seemed like the extra one.